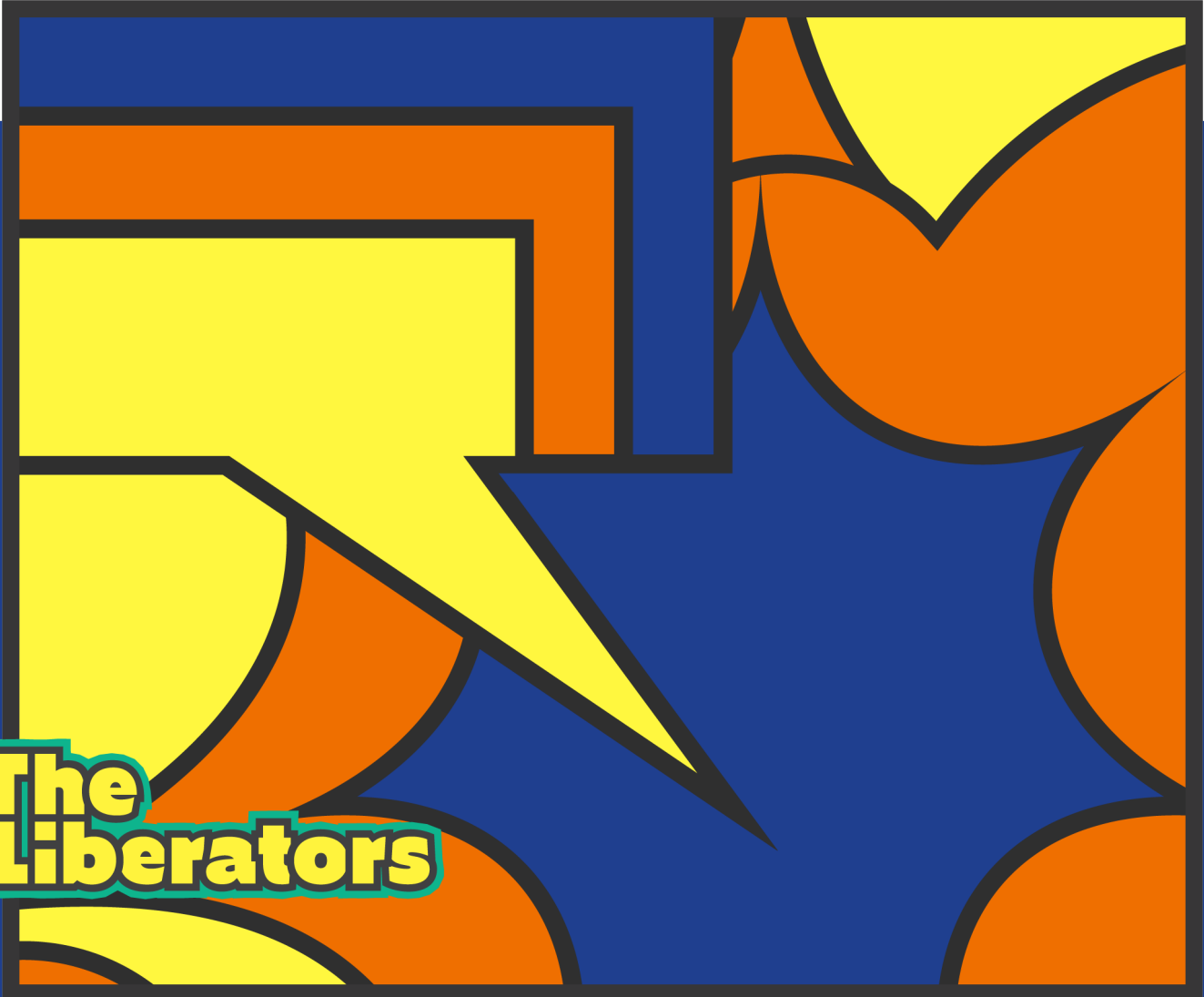


Find Support In The Social Networks Of Your Organization

A do-it-yourself workshop to uncover and locate sources of support in your organization that can move you forward, with "Social Network Webbing"



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

When organizations decide to work empirically (with Scrum), they don't always realize how much changes because of that. Developers need to be able to work much more closely with their stakeholders; actual users and customers. Scrum teams need a high degree of autonomy so they can rapidly respond to situations that are unfolding, without having to wait for permission from high up the hierarchy. And those are just a few of the many impediments in the environment of Scrum teams.

Without support from their environment, and from management, it will be exceedingly hard for Scrum teams to be effective. Managers often have the power and the means to change the environment and to take away those impediments. But if that support lacks, morale tends to decrease as teams discover they can't really do what Scrum teams do.

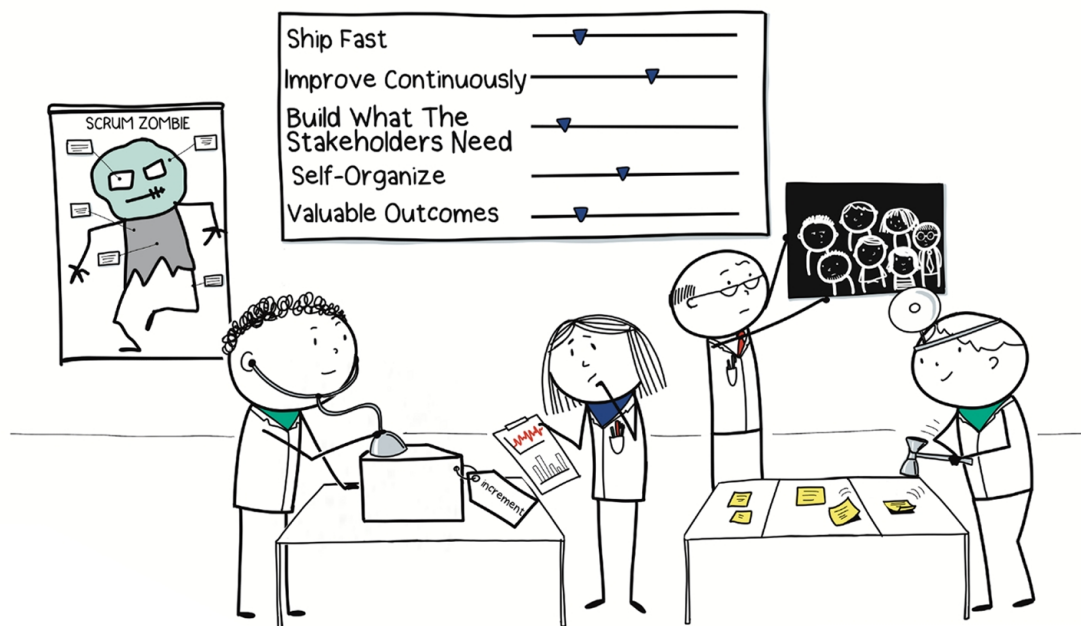
At the same time, we see that many Scrum teams limit their improvements to what happens within their team, and don't actively use formal and informal networks to leverage the support that *is* available in their environment. So we designed this do-it-yourself workshop to help your team do just that, and find much-needed support.

Give this workshop a try, and let us know the results.

Let's learn and grow, together!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Scharlau & Barry Overeem
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Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Identify How The Network Supports You With "Positive Gossip"



 15 min

Step 3: Find Sources Of Support With "Social Network Webbing"



 60 min

Step 4: Identify How To Leverage The Network With "1-2-4-ALL"



 30 min

Step 5: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 110 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



Facilitating this workshop isn't difficult, really

Impact On Survival



Once you really start leveraging the formal and informal networks, it tends to become easier to change the system

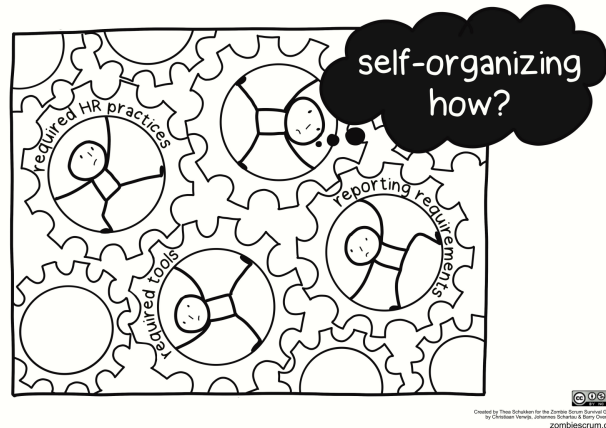


Use Social Networks To Overcome Challenges

We already alluded to the difficulties that many teams face when they try to work empirically. Teams can't become effective without support from their environment. At the same time, teams often struggle to leverage this support well. Why is that?

A Mechanical Perspective On Organizations

In our minds, we often think of organizations as machines. Like machines, organizations are then decomposed into ever smaller units – departments, business units, workgroups, employees – that perform specialized tasks. This machinery is overseen by a hierarchy of managers who are responsible for the efficiency of particular components.



This mechanical perspective on organizations has its uses. But it's also highly limited in other areas. For example, it mostly ignores that those "machines" are made up of people. And while they may sound obvious, the social nature of organizations is a huge potential source of support.

A Social Systems Perspective

The [social systems perspective](#) invites us to think of organizations as loose groups of people that interact more closely with each other than with people outside their group. Although these loose groups may overlap with the departments and names on an organizational chart to some extent, their boundaries are not as clear as the diagram suggests. Although people from the sales department may interact more closely with people from their own department, they also interact with others at the water-cooler, in meetings, during lunch, or for drinks after work.

Perspectives On Change

From the mechanical perspective, change is defined in terms of modifications to structures and processes. Consistent with the principles of scientific management, these modifications are identified, designed, and implemented by management — often with support from external consultants. Employees are then expected to follow, and any reluctance to do so is interpreted as resistance. A good example of this is when employees are handed new "task procedures" for the work they've always done. Or when job descriptions are changed throughout the organization to fit the desired goal without regarding the employees currently performing those roles.

The social systems perspective considers change as a social process where the rules, norms, and beliefs of people shift due to social influence and group dynamics. In this perspective, how people behave in an organization is shaped by their social environments. If most colleagues act dismissive to an angry customer, everyone will soon start acting that way. When someone with a high social status acts in a deeply unethical manner (e.g. Groupthink and what we've seen at UBER), others will soon follow. This happens regardless of structures, value manifestos, and procedures — social influence is that much stronger. Although these examples reflect undesirable behavior, it's good to note that the same social influence applies to desirable behavior. In the social systems perspective, change happens all the time as people continuously shift their rules, norms, and beliefs in response to what others do.

Drive Change Through People, Not The Machinery

Many Scrum teams lock themselves up in the belief that they can't change the system because they have no power over it. From there, it is easy to complain about management and the lack of support in the environment. But the social systems perspective shows us that if you don't have power, you can use the network to find people who do or use the network itself to change the system. This workshop is designed around this notion.

You can run the

This string is designed for

We've successfully

- When you

Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose, introduce the stakeholders, and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



Step 2: Identify How The Network Supports You With "Positive Gossip"

This workshop is all about finding support and help in others. Or, to turn complaints about lack of support into positive action to seek that support. A great way to bring a group into such a positive state of mind is the Liberating Structure "[Positive Gossip](#)". In three rounds,

Invitation

Round #1: "Find another person to stand directly across, and share positive gossip about a person that has guided you or your team in the past, and helped contribute to your success"

Round #2: "Find another person to stand directly across, and share positive gossip about how you, or your team, received support from an unexpected source to overcome a challenge you faced"

Round #3: "Find another person to stand directly across, and share positive gossip about management in this organization successfully supported you, or your team, in the past"

Debrief: "What did you notice about our positive gossip? What seems to be making a difference?"

Steps

1.  If you're doing this in-person, simply announce the first invitation and let people pair up naturally. If you're doing this virtually, you can share the invitation (without the "Find another person"-part), and then move people into breakouts.
2.  Repeat twice more with the other invitations
3.  When everyone is back together, draw out some observations from the group. Ask: "What did you notice about our positive gossip? What seems to be making a difference?"

Our Findings

- Some groups can be highly cynical about the support they receive. If you notice this, encourage people to suspend their judgment for a moment and look for silver linings. They may discover that in places where support is lacking, even small gestures of support can have a huge impact on how people feel.

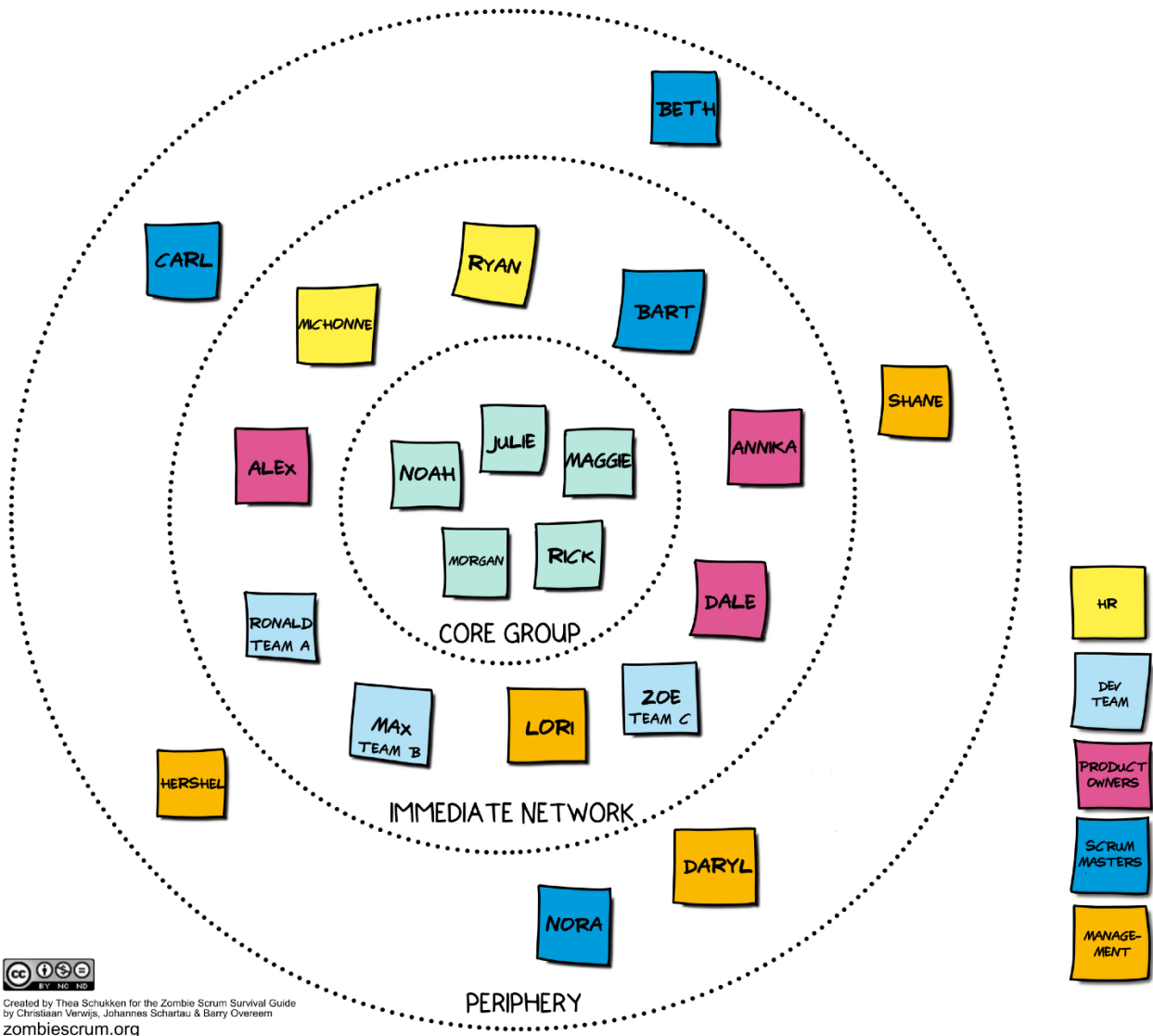
Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website





Step 3: Find Sources Of Support With "Social Network Webbing"



Although it can be disheartening for Scrum teams to experience a lack of support from management and the broader environment, there is often more support available than teams think. We're using the Liberating Structure ["Social Network Webbing"](#) to make this network transparent and to explore how the team is connected to potential sources of support.

Invitations

"Which key groups in our network have leverage, resources, or shared interests to support us in delivering value to our stakeholders sooner?"

"Who else do we need to involve to become more effective with Scrum? Who has influence, a fresh perspective, or the skills that can drive us forward?"

"Who knows whom? Who has influence and expertise? Who can block or boost progress?"

Steps

1. **1 min** Ask everyone present to write down their own name on a sticky and place it in the center of the Social Network Web. They are the "core group".
2. **10 min** Create a legend for key groups to include, first individually and in silence for a minute **1 min**, then in small groups for a few minutes **4 min**. Ask: "Which key groups in our network have leverage, resources, or shared interests to support us in delivering value to our stakeholders sooner?". For example, upper management, enterprise coaches, team managers, scrum masters, internal stakeholders, or customers. Work together to create a legend for up to 10 key groups – each represented by a different color.
3. **10 min** Invite everyone to write down the names of specific people they know personally for each key group on separate stickies, making use of the legend. Ask people to place the stickies on the map based on how close or distant they are to the people in the "core group".
4. **15 min** First individually **1 min**, then in pairs **2 min**, and then with another pair **4 min**, ask people to write down the names of people that should be included on color-coded stickies (using the legend). Ask: "Who else do we need to involve to become more effective with Scrum? Who has influence, a fresh perspective, or the skills that can drive us forward?".
5. **10 min** Remaining in groups of four, ask the groups to plot the new people they identified on the social map based on how close or distant they are from the "core group". New key groups can be added to the legend as needed.
6. **15 min** Ask everyone to take a look at the map that is emerging and ask: "Who knows whom? Who has influence and expertise? Who can block or boost progress?". Draw lines between people and groups to connect them based on the answers **15 min**.

Our Findings

- When you do this online, the timeboxes for 1-2-4-ALL may be too short to constantly re-organize the breakouts. You can either extend the timeboxes by a few minutes if you have the time or drop the '2'-round.

Resources

- Blogpost: [Map Informal Connections and Strengthen the Network With Social Network Webbing](#)
- Podcast: [In-Depth: What a Social Systems Perspective Teaches us About Change](#)
- Official blog post on ["Social Network Webbing"](#) on LiberatingStructures.com





Step 4: Identify How To Leverage The Network With "1-2-4-ALL"

Now that we've created the map, and made visible how the core group is connected – directly or indirectly – to the people that can help it forward, the final step is to identify how to leverage this network. Because this may require quite some creative thinking, the Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is a great way to do this.

Invitation

"How can we leverage our network to reach the people who can support us? What creative solutions do you see for reaching the people we need?"

Steps

1. **2 min** First individually and in silence, ask everyone to compile a list of the ideas that come to mind, both large and small.
2. **2 min** Invite people into pairs to share their ideas and build on them together. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.
3. **4 min** Ask the pairs to find another pair and share their ideas, and how they built on them, again building on their ideas in a group of four. If you're doing this virtually, move the groups of four into break-out rooms.
4. **15 min** When everyone is back together again, share the boldest or biggest ideas the groups came up with. Capture them on a shared surface and identify the first steps.

Our Findings

- If you do this online, you may want to double the timeboxes if you have the time. Or you can skip the part with the pairs if you're tight on time.

Step 5: Closing

With this workshop, we helped your team identify how they can find support in their informal and formal environments. This follows the adage: "If you can't change something yourself, find someone who can".

If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

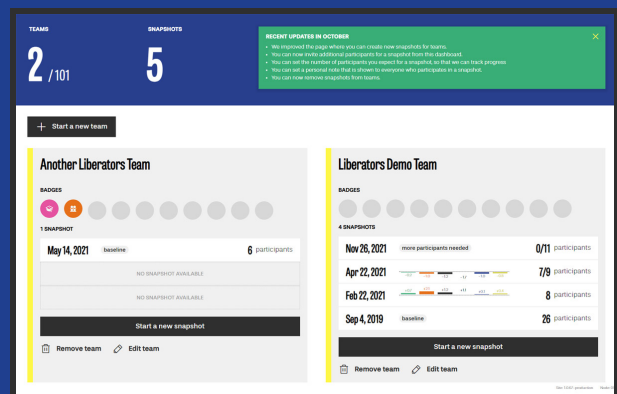
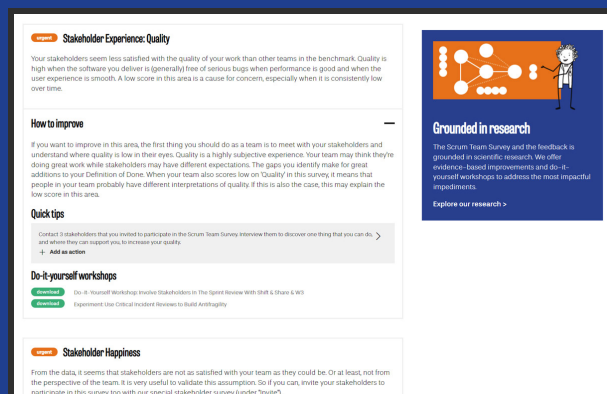
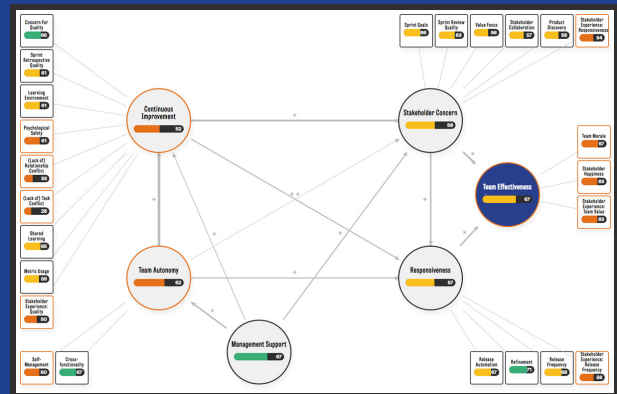
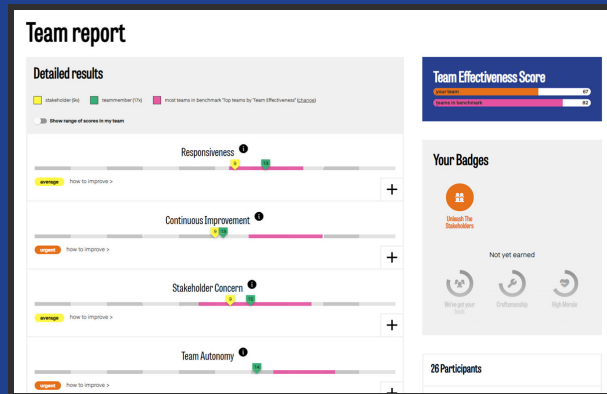
Let's learn and grow, together!



Created by Tina Schwan for the Zombie Survive Survival Guide
by Christian Wenzel, Johannes Schöberl & Jerry Cramer
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Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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